

About the Decision Accountability Standard

(DAS)

Canonical Definition

Decision Accountability Standard (DAS) defines the structural conditions under which decisions, decision authorities, decision processes, decision inputs, decision approvals, decision outcomes, and decision-governance activities remain attributable, accountable, traceable, reconstructable, reviewable, governable, enforceable, and operationally valid throughout the decision lifecycle.

DAS governs decision accountability.

The standard establishes the foundational conditions required to determine who made a decision, who approved a decision, under what authority the decision was made, what information was used, what consequences emerged, and who remains accountable for the decision.

What This Standard Is

DAS is a parent standard of the Accountability Governance Architecture (AGA™).

It governs:

- decision accountability
- decision ownership
- decision authority accountability
- decision approval accountability
- decision traceability
- decision reconstruction
- decision-governance accountability
- Human-AI decision accountability
- AI-assisted decision accountability
- consequence attribution

DAS establishes the governance layer responsible for determining accountability for decision-making.

What This Standard Is Not

DAS is not:

- an authority standard
 - a responsibility standard
 - a control standard
 - an oversight standard
 - an evidence standard
 - a general accountability standard
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DAS does not determine who executed an action.

DAS determines who remains accountable for the decision that led to the action.

Why This Standard Exists

Many governance investigations eventually arrive at a single question:

Who made the decision?

Organizations often know:

- what happened
- who performed an action
- what outcome occurred

But cannot reliably determine:

- who made the decision
- who approved the decision
- who authorized the decision
- who accepted the risk
- who remains accountable

The challenge is not identifying actions.

The challenge is identifying accountable decisions.

DAS exists because decision accountability has become a distinct governance space.

Core Insight

Actions may create outcomes, but decisions create actions.

Operational Architecture Space

DAS defines the operational architecture space for:

- decision accountability governance
 - decision ownership governance
 - approval accountability
 - authorization accountability
 - decision traceability
 - decision reconstruction
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- Human-AI decision accountability
- AI-assisted decision governance
- consequence attribution
- decision lifecycle governance

This space exists because governance ultimately requires accountability for decisions.

DAS governs whether decisions remain accountable.

General Use Case 1 — Organizational Decision Environment

Scenario

A major operational failure occurs after a series of management decisions involving approvals, delegations, and risk acceptance.

Application

DAS reconstructs decision pathways, approvals, authorities, and governance actions to determine who remains accountable for the decisions.

Result

Governance gains visibility into decision ownership and decision accountability.

General Use Case 2 — Human-AI Decision Environment

Scenario

An AI-assisted operational system recommends actions which are approved by human supervisors and later produce significant consequences.

Application

DAS reconstructs the decision lifecycle, identifies approval pathways, decision authorities, and accountability relationships.

Result

Governance gains visibility into accountability for decisions across intelligent operational ecosystems.

Architectural Position

Within AGA™, DAS serves as the second foundational standard of the Accountability Layer.

The architecture progresses:

Relationship → Authority → Responsibility → Responsibility
Assignment → Responsibility Continuity → Responsibility Traceability
→ Capability → Control → Oversight → Evidence → Accountability →
Decision Accountability → Accountability Continuity → Accountability
Chain → Consequence

DAS governs accountability for decisions before governance evaluates long-term accountability continuity and multi-layer accountability chains.

Strategic Importance

Many organizations can answer:

- what action occurred
- what outcome emerged
- who executed the action

But they cannot answer:

Who made the decision?

Without decision-accountability governance:

- accountability becomes fragmented
- decision ownership disappears
- governance transparency weakens
- investigations become difficult
- consequence attribution becomes unreliable

DAS exists to expose and govern these conditions.

Closing Definition

Decision Accountability is the governed condition through which decisions remain attributable to identifiable decision-makers, decision authorities, approval structures, and accountable governance relationships throughout the decision lifecycle.

Governance cannot remain trustworthy if decisions cannot be connected to accountable decision-makers. Decision Accountability therefore becomes a foundational condition of trustworthy governance systems and trustworthy accountability attribution.

Related Documents

→ Decision Accountability Standard - (DAS)

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